planet is qualified to make a call on when a misjudgement cannot be forgiven.

Hansie was certainly the best captain for whom I've ever played. Despite the cloud that hangs over his legacy, I can tell you that I've never played with anyone who possessed such a die-hard attitude to winning. Hansie wanted to win at any cost; he was a *great* competitor. We were all in awe of the guy – Hansie was one of those men who had a special presence towards which others gravitate. His other great asset as a captain – actually the *biggest* positive, as far as I am concerned – was that he never got too close to his players. Maintaining a distance allowed him to put players in their place when it was required. From what I've heard, as captains, Steve Waugh was and Ricky Ponting is much the same.

And, man, could Hansie lay down the law! *No one* would contradict him – not even the senior guys like Brian McMillan or Allan Donald – not only because his teammates had respect for him, but also because Hansie basically took no shit.

Hansie was also hard core about players' fitness. For example, in a training session ahead of a tour, Hansie told Pat Symcox that if he didn't run a certain amount on the bleep test, he wouldn't go on tour. 'If you can't run this on the bleep test, you can't go. Simple as that. I don't care whether you're in or out of form – if you can't run the bleep test well, you are not fit enough. And then you're not going.'

Bleep tests are shuttle runs between two lines that are 20 metres apart. You start off almost at a walking pace. There are 10 or 11 shuttles at every level, and every subsequent level gets quicker and quicker. You've got to reach at least level 12 or 13, which means doing 120 or 130 shuttles. Old Patrick liked his beer and his cigarettes, but somehow he managed to run it.

Along with his no-shit attitude, Hansie also had a tremendous sense of humour, and he'd occasionally surprise us with his fun and mischievous side. One night in particular illustrates this side of the man perfectly …

The West Indies were touring South Africa in 1998. The second Test was in Port Elizabeth and, thanks to an 'interesting' pitch, the wickets were tumbling. We'd batted first, getting 245, then skittled the opposition for 121. By the end of the second day, we were already 145/5.

Still, with a lead of 266 and five wickets in hand, it was pretty clear we were going to win the game. We'd also won the first Test, at a canter, by four wickets. I must admit, I had a bit of a 'mare in this game – scoring two